

Pei brings drama to Dallas

The new City Hall in Dallas is the most dramatic structure of its type since Boston's a decade ago.

Like Boston's, Dallas's building stands alone, its concrete upper floors jutting forward, as Boston's do, to command a plaza that is meant to be the new center of the city.

It's another stunning, controversial blockbuster by the architect who has become America's semi-official designer of public monuments, I. M. Pei.

The Pei firm did the Christian Science Center, the Hancock Tower, and the Kennedy Library here and has on the drawing boards a new wing for the Museum of Fine Arts. Increasingly, this office is the one being turned to by anyone who wants and can afford certified, instant prestige.

Clients get what they've paid for, too: Pei's latest, the new National Gallery addition in Washington which we'll report on in the near future, has already been featured in *Time*, *Newsweek*, *Esquire*, and the *New York Times* magazine. At age 61, Pei enjoys a position held, perhaps, by no other American architect since Richardson.

Pei stays successful by remaining the fixed point in a churning world of changing architectural fashion. He's safe but not stodgy, never avant-garde and never passe. And what may seem questionable in his severe, geometric, formal buildings is offset by the craftsmanship with which they are executed.

Dallas City Hall (or Municipal Administration Center, to give it its proper name, dreamed up by the kind of bureaucrat who thrilled in his youth to Army training manuals) has the strengths and weaknesses of all Pei's work.

Looked at from one viewpoint, it's an egotistical sculpture, one man's arbitrary exercise in shape-making, a straining for novelty that ends as a stunt. Bigger at the top than the bottom, it calls attention to itself in much the same way as a man standing on his hands.

It's a huge, self-contained object set in a sea of space, almost like a stranded aircraft carrier. It's too aloof, not reaching out socially in any way to the build-

ARCHITECTURE By ROBERT CAMPBELL

ings around it, not part of the weave of the city. It's too finished, too perfect, made all of the same flawless buff concrete, unwelcoming to the idea of change or addition over time.

If those are weaknesses, the building also has great strength. Masterfully sited at the south edge of downtown, the 550-foot long main face looks north with that powerful visor-like outward tilt. So forceful is the thrust into space that it helps orient your whole perception of Dallas. Three big concrete drums thrust upward to break the long ribbons of concrete and glass. The drums contain fire stairs and mechanical equipment and mark the location of elevator cores deeper in the building. The whole effect is brought off with sophistication and drama.

In front of the City Hall is a huge public plaza made of concrete paving, a fountain and some trees, with the obligatory Henry Moore sculpture still to come. Under the Texas sun this is a place of glare and discomfort, inhabited, most of the time, principally by a population of little round-topped concrete bollards, lined up like soldiers. In a downtown that is being gnawed around its edges by too much vacant space, this parade ground, which the architects persuaded the city to acquire, isn't helpful.

The plaza also means that the building always looks the same. Everything is organized and there's only one viewpoint. Where Boston's City Hall can be approached in numberless ways, seen down narrow streets or over the tops of older buildings, across its plaza or even from below at the markets, Dallas, lacking that kind of varied urban grain, presents its City Hall on a podium. No matter how you come at it the view and scale are the same and after that first "Wow!" your interest flags.

Indoors the building is at its best. A marvelous skylit atrium runs the full length, gathering all the workspace around it into an understandable whole. Everyone can see everyone else, you can't get lost, you're never out of

sight of the outdoors, yet there's privacy and variety. Bridges cross the atrium, connecting one department with another, an exciting alternative to the usual corridors. Open, so-called "landscape" office planning makes the most of the long dramatic spaces. Throughout the whole interior is a sense of lightness and balance that's admirable.

Dallas City Hall certainly isn't the equal, architecturally, of Boston's, but it just might be a better place to work. If the exterior is theatrical and a little thin, this is still a well planned, vivid and successful building.

Interior of City Hall (right) is organized around a skylit central gallery that runs almost the full length of the building. Spaces are exciting and well organized.

New Dallas City Hall (below) by I. M. Pei and Partners juts forward over huge plaza. Round towers break the building's monotony, mark locations of elevators and frame the entrance. Building's dramatic shape is seen by some as powerful, by others as theatrical.

